

CLASS OF '27 COMMON APP GUIDE

The Application Process summed up

First of all, before knowing how to apply, you have to know the two application cycles when you are allowed to apply.

(i)Early Decision Cycle- deadline to apply to a school of your choice is 1st November and the results, acceptance or rejection, come during mid-December. In this cycle, you can only apply to one school. Your number one dream school. Note if you get an acceptance, you will be legally entitled to attend this school unless they give you a low scholarship(also known as financial aid) amount.

(ii)Early Action Plan- Early action plans are nonbinding - you will receive an early response to your application (decision dates come out in mid-December) but do not have to commit to the college until the normal reply date of May 1. You can therefore apply to more than one school with the EA plan. But do not apply to two schools early if one of them is an Early Decision School. But if both have the EA plan, then you are good to go.

(iii)Restrictive Early Action Plan- Restrictive Early Action (sometimes Restricted Early Action) is another non-binding option. You aren't obligated to attend if accepted. However, if you apply Restrictive Early Action, you may *not* apply to any other schools in the early rounds. Applicants are expected to sign a statement that they agree to file only one early application.

Applying REA clearly indicates to the school that they are your number one choice, and it can significantly increase your chances of acceptance. Like EA applicants, REA applicants have until May 1 to make their decision.

(iv)Regular Decision Cycle- the deadline to apply to other schools of your choice is usually early January. It can be as early as the 1st of January for some schools but they vary. Here you can apply to a maximum of 19 schools. Note you only apply to this cycle if you don't get an acceptance from your first Early Decision school. So here you will do applications to 19 schools, each school has its own essays to write and you only have two weeks to do this (between mid-December and early January) so it is quite hectic. So I would advise you to prepare and start writing these essays immediately after you have sent your ED application. It will save you time and mental sanity! The results of these schools come out between mid-March and early April.

There are two parts of applications to universities in the US that are common

(i) **The Common App.** <https://apply.commonapp.org/>

(ii) **The College Board.** <https://www.collegeboard.org/>

The difference between the Common App and The College Board

(i) The common app is an application in the play store that can be downloaded for free. It is the platform that you use to select the colleges you want to apply to, write their specific essays there and send them to the school's admission committees for review. Notice getting admission to a school is quite different from getting a scholarship. You first have to get admission to the school through the common app to secure funding(scholarship) from the school that you've been admitted to.

(ii) Applying for scholarships or funding is done through the [College Board](https://www.collegeboard.org/). So this platform is where you will fill in your financial details as well as your parents'. This is a very thorough document that asks even personal questions about your homestead's economical situation, your parent's tax returns, and even some of the properties that you and your family have as assets. So on this website, you will also indicate the name of the same schools you indicated in the common app that you're interested in applying to ensure parity.

1. The Common App

Okay, let's start with the [Common app](https://apply.commonapp.org/).

- Download it and create an account with your email (a newly formed separate email would be convenient for this)

- After downloading and installing it, click on the section tagged as "Common App." Here you'll find subsections that you are supposed to fill. These are personal details including the family's level of education, your academic achievements, the activities you did in and out of school, and a Personal Essay. But I will have to give you details of the most important part of the Common App; The PS!

1.1 The Personal Statement

This subsection is found in the “Writing” part of “Common App.” A ps is an essay you write about yourself. It is a personal story about yourself that shouldn’t be inclined solely on your academics/academic journey but more on your vulnerable self as a human.

“Have you faced something in life that has affected you emotionally/mentally and have battled it or have found a way to live with it?” is a very important question you need to ask yourself. Take note that this is the most important part of the common app application, but don’t disregard others as less important.

Good examples from the website. Click [here](#) and [here](#) to find a good guide in writing a good PS. Also, check out these [Youtube videos](#). This is the most trusted person that might help you find a good story to write. This is the part where your writing proficiency and self-expression will serve as a reward or loss for you. And even if your activities and grades are a hundred % good, they won’t make you a memorable applicant.

N.B - Also included in the “Writing” section is the “Additional Information” essay that is optional to write. It is the part where any missing information or any information that you see important, and can raise your chances of being admitted but was not indicated in other parts of the Common App is written.

Other sections of the common app include filling in your grades, both the KCSE one and the one from the high school transcript, it also includes telling the school that you cannot pay the application fees, indicating your level of education, and so on.

If you have any questions while filling these parts of the common app reach out to your mentors.

- Other subsections include;

2. “College Search” which you will use to look for your prospective schools and add them to your college list that will appear in your “My Colleges Section.” Click [here](#) to find the various websites that can help you in choosing a school.

NOTE: Only add a school after checking on their website the keywords “financial aid for international students.” This will help you know if the school covers the whole cost of the scholarship or not. If they indicate they have “Need-Based Aid” then you can consider that school for application. So take your time in building the college list!

3. “Dashboard” where you will see your colleges and their application deadlines. Click on those college icons and find the questions that each college asks. These questions are also inclusive of essays that the schools ask you to write.

These essays inquire about the question “Why did you choose to apply to ‘me’?” These essays expect you to tell the school how interested you are in them, how well you know the school and its resources, and how these would lead to your growth both intellectually and socially.

They also expect you to tell them how you would be a benefit to the school. For example, how will you add to the research that a certain professor has done, or even which social aspects of you will you bring to campus. It entails knowing a lot about the school and weaving them to how they suit you and how you would also benefit them in return. You can also be asked to write which course you intend to study there and why it appeals to you and yet the same course is present in other universities worldwide. So that you distinguish yourself, you will have to know a lot about the school, the research it does in that particular course, and how you see yourself benefitting from it and also be of benefit to it. SO RESEARCH RESEARCH!

4. “My Colleges” section. Click on the icon of these colleges. You will find the same things as you did above. You will also find a part named “Recommenders & FERPA.” This is where you will get the chance to invite subject teachers to be your recommenders. You will also invite the school counselor, who in our case is Mr. Odinga. The three will write you a recommendation letter. The School Counselor will also send your transcripts(also known as a mid-year report), your fee waiver request(used to exempt you from paying application fees), and your KCSE result slip(also known as Final Report)

So what we do is that we write our own recommendations. Like we praise ourselves well on behalf of the teachers, and after satisfaction, you send the rec to the invited teachers who will then stamp them for official purposes and send them through their own portal. It's being realistic because recommendations require the teachers to write descriptively, and talk about some specific stories about you that would help them explain a certain trait that you have, and honestly they will not find time to do all of these for you. But our school counselor is usually willing to write his own recommendation if you give him well-explained anecdotes about you that you would want him to exploit a trait about you. Since you will be writing the other recommendations for yourself, click [here](#) to see how best to draft and write a good and compelling recommendation. It is really important for the colleges to know how teachers see you in class and so you should do your best. Click [here](#) to find a good example. Start talking with teachers who you know well and can work with. You can also request a recommendation from a mentor for a certain activity that you have done out of school. For example a recommendation from an agent in NACADA whom you interacted with when you did a community service activity that sought to campaign against drugs. Feel free to request

your mentors of their recommendations (if they allow) to see how descriptive a recommendation should be.

5. Financial Aid/Resources” section. This part is important as it will direct you to know the scholarship opportunities available in the schools that you added to your college list.

(ii)The College Board

As I indicated earlier. This is where you will fill in your family’s economic situation. This will involve getting your parent’s tax returns, and other forms of income like assets, and asking them a lot about their expenditure on household stuff like clothes food, and even electricity. Note you will also be asked how much your parents use to educate your siblings in their various levels of education.

NB: Write all these figures down for reference because sometimes you can lose them. They are also important in comparing two things. Your family’s total income value against its expenditures. These values should not have a huge gap and the value of income should be higher. Having a lower income value than the expenditure will deem your application as “unrealistic” and can be used in disqualifying you.

So keep all those details written somewhere. If one value outweighs the other, just change other individual values to make an appropriate gap. It takes a lot of time, so you might want to start doing this early!

NOTE: Some schools don't use the College Board for financial aid applications. So they may have their own website used to apply for funding or scholarship. For Example, the University of Chicago and the University of Pennsylvania have their own websites.

Buy a 200 A4 book to do your applications. THAT IS A NECESSITY. Unless you are ready to lose everything and start from zero.

REMEMBER ALL THIS IS HECTIC. IT CAN TAKE EVEN MONTHS! SO DON'T GIVE UP!